

Word family: **overhead / overheads**

Base word: overhead

Plural: overheads (mainly business-cost sense, especially BrE)

Part of speech: noun (名詞) / adjective (形容詞) / adverb (副詞)

Your sentence:

> “Put simply, tutors earn private income while restaurants absorb the hidden **overhead**.”

Meaning in this passage

Here, **overhead** means **indirect operating costs that a business must pay even though they are not directly attributable to one particular sale, product, or customer**.

In the passage, those hidden costs may include things such as rent, electricity, staff time, cleaning, seating capacity, and other operating resources consumed while tutorial groups occupy the restaurant.

繁體中文：** **間接營運成本；間接費用；企業維持日常運作所承擔、但不能直接歸入某一筆銷售或某一項產品的成本**

中文翻譯：

> “...restaurants absorb the hidden **overhead**.”

「.....餐廳卻要自行承擔那些隱藏的**間接營運成本 / 間接費用**。」

Here:

hidden overhead = 補習活動沒有直接支付、但實際由餐廳承擔的間接營運開支

1. **overhead = indirect business operating costs (商業 / 會計) — 間接成本；間接費用；營運開支**

This is the exact meaning used in your passage.

Practice 1 — Original

> “Restaurants are forced to absorb the additional **overhead**.”

「餐廳被迫自行承擔額外的**間接營運成本**。」

Practice 2

> “The company is trying to reduce its **overhead**.”

「公司正設法降低**間接營運成本**。」

Practice 3

> “Rent and administrative salaries form part of the firm’s **overhead**.”

「租金和行政人員薪酬構成公司的部分**間接費用**。」

overhead = 維持企業運作所需，但不能直接歸屬於某一件產品、某一位顧客或某一宗銷售的成本

Common examples may include:

- * rent
- * utilities
- * insurance
- * administrative salaries
- * office expenses
- * maintenance

The exact classification depends on the accounting context.

2. **overheads** = business running expenses (複數，尤其英式) — 經常性營運開支；**間接費用**

Especially in British English, **overheads** is very common.

Practice 4

> “Small businesses often struggle with high **overheads**.”

「小型企業經常因高昂的**營運開支 / 間接成本**而感到吃力。」

Practice 5

> “Moving to a smaller office reduced our **overheads**.”

「搬到較小的辦公室降低了我們的**營運開支**。」

So:

> **overhead**
> and
> **overheads**

can both refer to business indirect expenses, though usage varies by dialect and accounting style.

3. **fixed overhead / variable overhead (會計) — 固定 / 變動間接成本**

A common learner mistake is assuming:

> **overhead = fixed cost**

That is **not always true**.

fixed overhead

does not change much with short-term production volume:

- * building rent
- * certain salaried administrative costs

variable overhead

can change with activity levels:

- * some utilities
- * indirect materials
- * certain support costs

So the broader concept is:

> **indirect cost**

rather than simply:

> **fixed cost**

4. **manufacturing overhead = indirect manufacturing cost (製造業) — 製造間接費用**

In manufacturing accounting, **manufacturing overhead** refers to production-related costs that cannot conveniently be traced directly to individual units.

Examples may include:

- * factory rent
- * factory utilities
- * equipment depreciation
- * indirect labour
- * indirect materials

Practice 6

> “The company allocates manufacturing **overhead** to each product.”

「公司把製造**間接費用**分配到各項產品上。」

This is a specialist application of Meaning 1.

5. **administrative overhead** = administration-related indirect cost (行政) — 行政間接成本

Practice 7

> “The charity aims to keep administrative **overhead** low.”

「該慈善機構希望把行政**間接開支**維持在低水平。」

administrative overhead = 維持管理、辦公、行政功能的間接成本

This stays under the business-cost branch.

6. **overhead** = extra resource/time required to make a system operate (一般 / 科技) — 額外負擔；附加成本

The business meaning has extended strongly into computing, engineering, project management, and systems analysis.

Here, **overhead** means resources consumed by the process itself rather than by the main useful task.

Practice 8

> “Encryption adds some processing **overhead**.”

「加密會增加一些處理上的**額外負擔 / 額外運算成本**。」

Practice 9

> “The extra approval process creates unnecessary administrative **overhead**.”

「額外的審批流程造成不必要的行政**額外負擔**。」

overhead = 為了讓某個系統 / 流程運作而額外消耗的時間、記憶體、處理能力、人力或其他資源

This is a major modern abstract extension.

7. **computing overhead** = extra processing/memory/data required by the system itself (電腦)
— 系統開銷；額外運算負擔

In computing, **overhead** can refer to resources that support a task but are not the task's useful output itself.

Examples:

- * CPU overhead
- * memory overhead
- * protocol overhead
- * virtualization overhead
- * network overhead

Practice 10

> “The software introduces significant memory **overhead**.”

「這套軟件會產生相當大的記憶體**額外開銷**。」

Practice 11

> “Each packet contains protocol **overhead**.”

「每個資料封包都包含協定所需的**額外控制資料**。」

This is an important modern technical sense.

8. **overhead** = above your head / in a higher position (形容詞) — 頭頂上的；上方的

Now we move to a completely different spatial meaning.

Practice 12

> “The **overhead** lights were too bright.”

「**頭頂上的**燈光太亮。」

Practice 13

> “Be careful of the **overhead** cables.”

「小心**上方**的**電纜**。」

overhead + noun = 位於人或物體上方 / 頭頂位置的

Common:

- * overhead lights
- * overhead wires
- * overhead cables
- * overhead compartment
- * overhead crane
- * overhead camera

This is a major core meaning distinct from business costs.

9. **overhead** = above one's head (副詞) — 在頭頂上方 ; 從上空

As an adverb:

Practice 14

> “A plane flew **overhead**.”

「一架飛機從**頭頂上空**飛過。」

Practice 15

> “We heard thunder **overhead**.”

「我們聽到雷聲從**上空**傳來。」

overhead = 在某人 / 某物正上方或上空

No following noun is needed in this use.

10. ****overhead compartment / bin (飛機) — 頭頂行李艙****

A very common travel compound:

> ****overhead compartment / overhead bin****

= ****飛機座位上方的行李艙****

Practice 16

> “Please place your bag in the ****overhead compartment****.”

「請把手提行李放進****頭頂行李艙****。」

This is simply the spatial adjective branch.

11. ****overhead line / wire (電力 / 鐵路) — 架空電線 ; 高架電纜****

Practice 17

> “The railway uses ****overhead lines**** to supply electricity.”

「鐵路使用****架空電纜****供電。」

Contrast:

> overhead cables

> underground cables

= 架空電纜 vs 地下電纜

This is a major infrastructure collocation, but not a new semantic core.

12. ****overhead crane (工程) — 橋式起重機 / 高架起重機****

An ****overhead crane**** operates above the working area, typically along rails or beams.

Practice 18

> “An **overhead crane** moved the heavy equipment across the factory.”

「一部**橋式 / 高架起重機**把重型設備移過工廠。」

Again, spatial branch.

13. **overhead shot** = image taken from above (攝影 / 電影) — 俯拍 ; 頂視鏡頭

Practice 19

> “The film opens with an **overhead shot** of the city.”

「電影開場是一個城市的**俯拍鏡頭**。」

overhead shot = 相機位於主體上方 , 向下拍攝的畫面

This is an established media/photography compound.

14. **overhead projector** = 投影機 / 高映機

An **overhead projector** is the older type of projector that projects enlarged images from transparencies onto a screen.

Practice 20

> “The teacher used an **overhead projector**.”

「老師使用了一部**投影機 / 高映機**。」

The technology is less central today but the term remains historically and educationally recognizable.

15. **overhead** = sports shot played from above the head (體育) — 過頂擊球 ; 高壓球

In sports such as tennis or badminton, **overhead** can describe a shot struck with the racket above the player's head.

Practice 21

> “She finished the point with an **overhead smash**.”

「她用一記**過頂高壓扣殺**拿下這一分。」

In tennis, **an overhead** can also function as a countable noun:

> “He missed an easy **overhead**.”

= 「他打失了一記很容易的**過頂高壓球**。」

This is a genuine sports noun/adjective sense.

16. **overhead kick (足球) — 倒掛金鉤**

In football:

> **overhead kick**

means an acrobatic kick in which a player kicks the ball backward over their own head while airborne.

Practice 22

> “He scored with a spectacular **overhead kick**.”

「他以精彩的**倒掛金鉤**入球。」

This belongs to the spatial/sports construction network.

17. **overhead press (健身) — 過頭推舉**

In weight training:

> **overhead press**

means pressing a weight upward until the arms are extended overhead.

Practice 23

> “She included the **overhead press** in her workout.”

「她的訓練包括**過頭推舉**。」

Again, not a new core meaning.

18. **overhead = supplementary burden in project/organizational work (項目 / 行政) — 間接工作量 ; 管理負擔**

This can sit between the business and computing senses.

Practice 24

> “Weekly reporting creates a lot of management **overhead**.”

「每週報告造成大量管理上的**額外工作量 / 間接負擔**。」

Practice 25

> “The process has too much coordination **overhead**.”

「這個流程需要太多協調上的**額外成本 / 工作量**。」

Here **overhead** may be:

- * time
- * meetings
- * documentation
- * coordination
- * administrative effort

rather than literal money.

This is an important modern abstract extension.

19. **overhead allocation / absorption (會計) — 間接成本分配 / 吸收**

Because we just covered **absorb**, this connection matters.

Businesses may:

> **allocate overhead**

= 把間接成本分配到部門 / 產品

or:

> **absorb overhead**

which can mean either:

1. **ordinary English:** bear/pay the overhead oneself;
2. **technical costing:** incorporate allocated overhead into product/service cost.

Example

> “Factory overhead is absorbed into product costs.”

「工廠間接費用被**吸收到** / 計入產品成本。」

Your passage uses the **ordinary business sense**:

> restaurants absorb the hidden overhead

= **餐廳自己承擔那些間接成本**

not a formal description of a costing methodology.

Important distinction: **overhead vs cost**

cost

is extremely broad.

Anything requiring money/resources can be a cost.

overhead

specifically refers to indirect operating cost or supporting resource consumption.

> ingredient cost

> staff overhead

> rent overhead

More accurately, some items can change classification depending on the business and accounting method.

Important distinction: **overhead vs direct cost**

direct cost

can be traced directly to a particular product/service/project.

Examples:

- * ingredients used in one meal
- * material used to manufacture a product

overhead

is indirect:

- * rent
- * shared electricity
- * administration

This is the core accounting contrast.

Important distinction: **overhead vs operating expense**

These overlap but are not automatically identical.

operating expenses

are expenses associated with running the business.

overhead

emphasizes that the cost is **indirect**, not directly attributable to a unit of production or sale.

Depending on accounting classification, some operating expenses may be overhead while others may be treated differently.

Important distinction: **overhead vs fixed cost**

fixed cost

= does not change significantly with activity volume over a relevant range.

overhead

= indirect cost.

Therefore:

> some overhead is fixed

> some overhead can be variable

Do not equate the two terms.

Important distinction: **overhead vs expense**

expense

is a general accounting/business word for money used up or charged against income.

overhead

is a more specific category of indirect/support cost.

Important distinction: **overhead vs burden**

This is particularly relevant to your previous entry.

burden

= something difficult, costly, or troublesome that someone must bear.

overhead

= indirect cost/resource required for operations.

So in the passage:

> tutorial use creates a **burden** on restaurants

and part of that burden consists of:

> hidden **overhead**

The first describes the **negative pressure**.

The second identifies a **type of cost**.

Important distinction: **overhead vs markup**

overhead

= cost to the business.

markup

= amount added to a product's cost to determine its selling price.

These move in opposite accounting directions conceptually:

> overhead increases the business's cost base

> markup increases the price charged

Important distinction: **overhead vs profit**

overhead

= expense/cost.

profit

= amount remaining after relevant costs are deducted from revenue.

High overhead can reduce profit.

Important distinction: **overhead vs surcharge**

surcharge

= extra amount charged to a customer.

overhead

= internal indirect operating cost.

A company may impose a surcharge to recover rising overhead, but they are not the same thing.

Important distinction: **overhead vs latency — computing**

overhead

= extra computational/resources needed to support the process.

latency

= delay before an action/result occurs.

Extra overhead may cause higher latency, but they are different measurements.

Important distinction: **overhead vs bandwidth — networking**

bandwidth

= data-transfer capacity.

protocol overhead

= control/header information that uses some of that capacity without being the end-user payload.

So high overhead can reduce the proportion of bandwidth available for useful data.

Grammar note: **overhead as an adjective**

It normally comes before a noun:

- > overhead light
- > overhead cost
- > overhead wire
- > overhead compartment

But note that **overhead cost** belongs to the business meaning, while **overhead light** belongs to the spatial meaning.

Context is essential.

Grammar note: ****overhead as an adverb****

> “The helicopter hovered overhead.”

Not:

> “overhead the building” ❌

For a prepositional idea, use:

> over the building

> above the building

Countability note

The grammar changes by sense.

Business costs

Usually uncountable in singular form:

> reduce overhead

> high overhead

Especially BrE, plural is common:

> reduce overheads

> rising overheads

Sports shot

Can be countable:

> hit an overhead

> miss two overheads

Spatial adverb/adjective

No countability issue:

> overhead lights

> flew overhead

Family-extension note

The morphological family is small:

* **overhead**

* **overheads**

But the word is semantically rich because it functions across several grammatical categories and domains:

- * business/accounting
- * computing/systems
- * spatial description
- * transport/aviation
- * infrastructure
- * photography
- * sport
- * engineering

Useful compounds include:

- * overhead cost
- * manufacturing overhead
- * administrative overhead
- * overhead rate
- * overhead allocation
- * computational overhead
- * protocol overhead
- * overhead wire
- * overhead compartment
- * overhead crane
- * overhead shot
- * overhead smash
- * overhead kick
- * overhead press

The central concepts are really two independent branches:

1. **something positioned above**
2. **indirect/supporting cost or resource burden**

These should not be artificially merged just because the spelling is the same.

Master comparison

Form / sense	MCQ-ready Traditional Chinese meaning
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overhead — business/accounting	維持企業運作但不能直接歸入某項產品、服務或交易的間接成本 / 間接費用
overheads — BrE business	企業日常的間接營運開支
manufacturing overhead	生產活動中的間接製造成本
administrative overhead	行政管理產生的間接成本
overhead — computing/system	為支援系統 / 流程運作而額外消耗的運算、記憶體、時間或資料資源
management/admin overhead	流程本身造成的額外協調、管理或文書負擔
overhead — adjective spatial	位於頭頂 / 上方的
overhead — adverb	在頭頂上方 / 從上空
overhead compartment	頭頂行李艙
overhead line/wire	架空電線 / 電纜
overhead shot	從上方俯拍的鏡頭
overhead — sport noun/adjective	從頭頂上方擊出的球 / 動作
overhead kick	足球倒掛金鉤
overhead press	過頭推舉

For your original sentence

> “Tutors earn private income while restaurants ****absorb the hidden overhead****.”

The exact meaning is:

****overhead = 餐廳因維持營業場所而持續承擔、但無法直接向補習老師或學生收取的間接營運成本****

So:

> ****hidden overhead****

= ****隱藏的間接成本 / 沒有被直接計價的營運開支****

This is more precise than simply:

> ****expense****

because ****overhead**** highlights ****indirect supporting costs**** rather than the direct cost of a specific item sold.

For your database, I would count ****3 genuinely useful core meanings**** for ****overhead****:

1. ****indirect business operating costs****
2. ****extra supporting resource/cost required by a system or process — especially computing/administration****
3. ****above the head / situated or moving overhead****

I would keep sports uses such as ****an overhead / overhead smash****, plus ****overhead kick****, as strong domain extensions of #3, and keep manufacturing/accounting compounds under #1 rather than multiplying the core unnecessarily.